vsftpd – Super Simple Summary for Newbies

(Perfect for IT support / network engineers who just need a reliable FTP server on Linux)

Topic	The Short & Sweet Answer
What is vsftpd?	Very Secure FTP Daemon – the most popular, lightweight, and secure FTP server for Linux (Ubuntu, CentOS, Rocky, Alma, Debian, etc.). Default in almost every distro.
Why use it instead of others?	• Extremely secure by default • Very fast and low memory • Huge amount of config options but works great with almost zero config • Actively maintained since 2001
Typical use cases	• Internal file transfers • Upload/download area for customers • Backup scripts • Docker/VM image repository

Absolute Minimal Working Setup (5 minutes)

1. Install (Ubuntu/Debian)

```bash
sudo apt update && sudo apt install vsftpd -y
```

   Install (RHEL/CentOS/Rocky/Alma)

```bash
sudo dnf install vsftpd -y   # or yum
```

2. Start and enable

```bash
sudo systemctl start vsftpd
sudo systemctl enable vsftpd
```

3. Allow in firewall (if active)

```bash
sudo ufw allow 20/tcp
sudo ufw allow 21/tcp
# For passive mode (recommended)
sudo ufw allow 40000:50000/tcp   # or your passive range
```

4. Test locally first

```bash
ftp localhost
# login with your Linux user account
```

That's it – it already works with system users (called "local users" mode).

Most Common Config File – Where Everything Lives

`/etc/vsftpd.conf` (or `/etc/vsftpd/vsftpd.conf` on some distros)

The 10 Lines You'll Actually Change 99% of the Time

Line in vsftpd.conf	What it does (just uncomment or change)
`anonymous_enable=NO`	Disables anonymous login (recommended)
`local_enable=YES`	Allows real Linux users to log in
`write_enable=YES`	Allows upload/delete
`chroot_local_user=YES`	Jails each user to their home directory (very important for security)
`allow_writeable_chroot=YES`	Needed on modern systems when chroot is on
`pasv_enable=YES`	Enables passive mode (required behind NAT/firewalls)
`pasv_min_port=40000`	Passive port range start
`pasv_max_port=50000`	Passive port range end
`seccomp_sandbox=NO`	Sometimes needed for SFTP clients or newer distros
`force_dot_files=YES`	Shows hidden files (optional)

After editing → restart:

```bash
sudo systemctl restart vsftpd
```

Quick Cheat Sheet – 3 Common Scenarios

Goal	What to do
Let normal Linux users FTP to their home	Default install + `chroot_local_user=YES` + `allow_writeable_chroot=YES`
Virtual users (not real Linux accounts)	Install `libpam-pwdfile` or use `db4` – a bit more work, ask if you need this

FTP with TLS/SSL (FTPS – encrypted)	Generate cert → add these lines:
	`ssl_enable=YES`
	`allow_anon_ssl=NO`
	`force_local_logins_ssl=YES`

Security One-Liner for Production

```conf
anonymous_enable=NO
local_enable=YES
write_enable=YES
chroot_local_user=YES
allow_writeable_chroot=YES
pasv_enable=YES
pasv_min_port=40000
pasv_max_port=50000
```

→ This combo is secure enough for 95% of internal/corporate use.

You're done.
vsftpd is now the simplest, most bullet-proof FTP server you'll ever manage.

Need a ready-made `/etc/vsftpd.conf` that just works securely? Reply "send config" and I'll give you the exact file.

↳ vsftpd virtual users setup

↳ proftpd vs vsftpd comparison

↳ more troubleshooting examples